STEHLEN AUTO · GROWTH PROPOSAL

Boosting Traffic: Paid Shopping + Free AI/Organic

A phased plan to grow qualified traffic to a site that already converts — without paying for clicks we can't fulfill.

Prepared for: **Ricky (Owner), Stehlen Auto**
Date: **July 17, 2026** · Data source: live Shopify + GA4 (G-YS6SFM9QFD)
Scope: **Google Shopping (paid) · ChatGPT + Organic (free) · Inventory readiness**

01 Executive Summary

The one-line strategy

The site converts on high-intent traffic; the constraint is **volume**. Restock the out-of-stock pockets first, then buy Google Shopping traffic concentrated on the vehicles we actually stock. The same product feed that powers paid Shopping also powers free ChatGPT and organic listings — so feed health lifts all three.

Three channels, three different levers — a critical distinction:

Channel	What it is	How you grow it	Status
Google Shopping (paid)	Pay-per-click product ads at the top of search	Turn on & fund the paid lane of the existing feed	READY TO LAUNCH
Organic search (free)	Unpaid Google/Bing rankings	SEO + healthy feed + in-stock, indexed SKUs	LIVE, HEALTHY
ChatGPT (free)	AI product recommendations	Merchant feed + Bing index + in-stock SKUs	LIVE — proven by orders

Key insight: You cannot *buy* your way into ChatGPT or organic rankings — there is no ad slot. But ~83% of ChatGPT product recommendations are sourced from Google Shopping's top-40 organic listings, so a well-maintained feed (which paid Shopping forces) indirectly strengthens ChatGPT too.

02 Where We Are Today

~2.7%	~9.1%	$191	1,322
MOBILE CONV. RATE	DESKTOP CONV. RATE	AVG. ORDER VALUE	ACTIVE SKUS

What's working

- **The site converts** on the traffic it gets — desktop at 9.1% is strong for auto parts.
- **The only channels producing sales are ChatGPT + Google organic + direct** — proof that high-intent search/AI traffic converts here.
- **Feed is approved & healthy:** Merchant Center shows 1.33K approved, 0 disapproved; GTIN-exemption resolved; already earning ~49 free Shopping clicks / 28 days (+158%).
- **Mobile conversion fixes shipped** (sticky add-to-cart, above-fold fitment, cart hygiene) — mobile CR should improve from here.
- **Inventory sync verified** running hourly and accurate against the warehouse source of truth.

The core problem

Traffic volume, not conversion. Recent traffic surges came from low-intent/untracked sources and did not convert. The fix is to buy the *right* traffic (high-intent Shopping) and grow the free channels — not to chase raw session count.

03 Step 1 — Inventory Readiness (Do This First)

> **Why this comes before spending a dollar:** An out-of-stock product cannot be recommended by ChatGPT, cannot rank in organic Shopping, and — if advertised — burns paid clicks on something nobody can buy. Fixing stock is the single highest-leverage move because it unlocks *all three* channels at once.

In-stock coverage by marketed vehicle (live, MY2020 proxy)

Vehicle	Fitting SKUs	In stock	%	Verdict
Ram 1500	63	59	93%	**Advertise now — best target**
Nissan Frontier	22	21	95%	**Advertise now**
Toyota Tundra	36	33	91%	**Advertise now**
GMC Sierra	7	6	85%	**Thin catalog**
Chevy Silverado	11	8	72%	**Thin catalog**
Ford F-150	29	20	68%	**Good, but exclude dry cats**
Toyota Tacoma	28	19	67%	**Good, but exclude dry cats**
Jeep Wrangler	1	1	100%	**Catalog gap (1 SKU)**

Dry pockets to restock (highest demand, currently invisible)

Vehicle × Category	In stock	Action
Ford F-150 · Trailer Hitches	**0 / 4**	Restock — #1 US truck, top-demand fitment sitting dry
Toyota Tacoma · Running Boards	**1 / 7**	Restock — popular accessory, 6 OOS
Chevy Silverado · Bull Guards	**1 / 4**	Restock
F-150 / GMC Sierra · Bull Guards	**0 / 1**	Restock (minor)

Note: verified real warehouse stockouts against CB source-of-truth — not a sync bug. The ball-mount component (TH-BMOUNT-L2) at 0 also silently blocks both F-150 hitch *combo* listings.

04 Step 2 — Google Shopping Campaign Plan

Campaign type: Standard Shopping (not Performance Max)

Standard Shopping gives us **SKU/category-level control** — essential because our catalog has stockout pockets that Performance Max (a black box) would happily spend on. PMax also needs conversion history we don't yet have. **Hold PMax until 30+ paid conversions/month.**

Structure: 1 campaign, 3 ad groups by vehicle tier

Ad group	Vehicles	Max CPC	Rationale
Tier 1	Ram 1500, Tundra, Frontier	$0.90–1.20	91–95% in stock + deepest catalog — concentrate spend here
Tier 2	Sierra, Silverado, F-150, Tacoma (dry cats excluded)	$0.50–0.75	Healthy but thinner / partial dry pockets
Catch-all	Everything else	$0.40–0.60	Low bid, ride passively, no dedicated budget

Budget & pacing

- **Start: $50/day ($1,500/mo).** No increase until the campaign proves a workable cost-per-acquisition.
- **Scale gate:** only raise budget (+25–50% per step) after **15 conversions** in a rolling 30 days *and* CPA at/below breakeven.

Bidding strategy

- **Start: Manual CPC** — gives tier control; Smart Bidding can't learn on our low conversion history.
- **At 15 conv./30d** → switch to Maximize Conversions.
- **At 30 conv./30d** → introduce Target ROAS (~240% initial target, tighten from there).

> ⚠ **Do not skip: Conversion tracking.** Google Shopping cannot optimize without conversions counting in Google Ads. Because our GA4 `purchase` event is now server-side, it carries `client_id` + UTMs but **not** `gclid` — so ~15–20% of ad conversions (Safari/iOS, ad blockers) may not stitch. **Treat Google Ads' conversion count as a floor; Shopify orders remain the revenue truth.** Gold-standard fix (month 2): capture `gclid` into the order and feed offline conversions back — a small, scoped engineering task we can do.

05 The Economics (Honest)

Assumes ~$1.00–1.20 CPC → ~1,250–1,500 clicks/mo at $1,500 spend; AOV $191. **Gross margin assumed 35% — please confirm; the 25% case is shown for stress-testing.**

Scenario	Conv. rate	Orders/mo	Revenue	Net @ 35% margin	Net @ 25% margin

Breakeven threshold	1.5–1.8%	~22	~$4,300	$0	tighter (needs ~2.1–2.5%)
Month 1 (learning)	~1.5%	~20	~$3,900	**≈ –$135**	**≈ –$525**
Month 3 (optimized)	~2.5%	~37	~$7,100	**≈ +$985**	≈ +$275

> **Read this honestly:** Month 1 is a data-buying cost, not profit — that is normal and expected for a new Shopping campaign. Breakeven at 35% margin is achievable even at current *mobile* conversion alone, which is the encouraging signal. Confirming true margin is the single most important input.

06 Feed Hygiene, Geo & Negatives

- **Titles stay as-is** — already YMM-formatted ("2015-2025 Ford F-150 Class 3 Trailer Hitch"). Do not rewrite.
- **Auto-exclude OOS:** Shopify's Google channel drops zero-inventory SKUs automatically — verify on 2–3 known-dry SKUs before launch.
- **Manual exclude:** Tacoma's single in-stock running board — could sell out mid-flight; flag it until the category has 3+ SKUs.
- **Custom labels** to add: vehicle tier, margin tier, stock-risk flag, dry-pocket override — enables bid segmentation without engineering tickets.
- **Geo:** United States, "presence" targeting only.
- **Negatives to seed:** used, salvage, junkyard, wiring diagram, recall, lawsuit, dealer, rental, jobs; non-truck types (car, sedan, motorcycle, atv, boat, rv). Review search-query report weekly for month 1.
- **Device:** no mobile bid adjustment for 2–3 weeks — mobile fix just shipped; gather post-fix data first.

07 90-Day Roadmap

Phase	Window	What happens	Gate to advance
0 — Readiness	Week 0	Restock dry pockets (F-150 hitches, Tacoma boards); confirm margin; link Merchant Center ↔ Google Ads ↔ GA4; set up conversion tracking	Stock in; accounts linked; conversion action live
1 — Launch	Week 1	1 campaign / 3 ad groups; $50/day; Manual CPC; negatives + geo set; Tier 1 (Ram/Tundra/Frontier) prioritized	Live, no disapprovals, impressions flowing
2 — Stabilize	Wk 2–4	Weekly search-query negative pass; hold budget; tune tier bids	≥15 conversions / rolling 30d
3 — Tighten & scale	Wk 5–8	Switch to Maximize Conversions; +25–50% budget if CPA holds; build gclid capture for airtight attribution	≥30 conversions / 30d, CPA stable 2 wks
4 — Expand	Wk 9–12	Introduce Target ROAS; test PMax as a separate small campaign; light retargeting on existing GA4 audiences	Ongoing CPA discipline

> **Discipline rule:** Never advance a phase on hope. If Month 2 doesn't hit 15 conversions, stay in Phase 2 and fix the campaign — do not throw more budget at an unproven CPA.

08 Growing the Free Channels (ChatGPT + Organic)

These run in parallel with paid Shopping at no media cost. Most infrastructure is already live:

Lever	Effect	Status
IndexNow auto-ping to Bing on catalog change	Fresh pages feed Bing → ChatGPT Search	DONE
Merchant Center feed (approved)	Feeds Google Shopping *and* ChatGPT recs	DONE
Rich PDP structured data (Product/Offer/Vehicle/Brand/MPN)	Why AI engines cite the catalog	DONE
Agentic (ChatGPT) sales channel present in Shopify	Automatic discovery in ChatGPT	CONFIRMED
Restock dry pockets	Makes more SKUs eligible to be found for free	ACTION
Merchant Center: set Return window (30d) + cost (Free)	Unlocks "Free 30-day returns" badge on free listings	ACTION (owner)

> **Bottom line for free channels:** for a transactional parts catalog, AI/organic visibility comes from **product data + feed + indexing + in-stock coverage** — not from mass-produced blog content (which risks site-

quality penalties in 2026). Skip "AI SEO autopilot" tools.

09 Who Does What

Owner (Ricky) — this week

- Confirm gross margin (changes the whole math)
- Restock decision on dry-pocket SKUs
- Link Merchant Center ↔ Google Ads ↔ GA4 (account access, ~10 min)
- Approve $50/day budget + payment method
- Set Merchant Center return window/cost
- Sign off at each phase gate

Can be executed for you

- Campaign build, ad-group structure, bid tiers
- Negative keyword list + weekly query review
- Custom-label feed tagging
- gclid-capture attribution code (Phase 3)
- Weekly reporting (Shopify = revenue truth)
- OOS feed-exclusion verification

10 Recommended Next Action

Do these four this week — none require waiting on engineering

1) Confirm gross margin. 2) Green-light restock of F-150 hitches + Tacoma running boards. 3) Link Merchant Center ↔ Google Ads ↔ GA4 and set up the GA4-import conversion action. 4) Verify 2–3 known-dry SKUs are absent from the live feed. Then we launch Standard Shopping at $50/day on Ram 1500 / Tundra / Frontier.

Prepared by Claude Code for Stehlen Auto · figures from live Shopify Admin API + GA4 Data API on 2026-07-17 · projections are directional and should be re-based on real week-1 campaign data · Shopify orders remain the source of truth for revenue.